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TEJPAL DEFIES
THE MORAL
STRAITJACKET

believe of the journalist, we witness how the dynamics of domination reduces the distance between the worlds of the wretched and the privileged. *The Story of My Assassins* is powered by the overwhelming humanism of a novelist who defies the moral straitjacket.

As the story meanders through the darkest recesses of India, the killers turn victims and the "targeted" journalist becomes a pawn in a state whose law and justice system mimes the imagination of Kafka. It is the killers' back stories, set in the brutalised countryside, that bring out the best from the storyteller, a natural at his peak. All of

them are shaped to deadly perfection by the conspiracy of ancestry and the attitudes of a society that shows no mercy. They are more than the artists of knife and hammer; they are anti-heroes of detached action, immortalised by police files. Their stories provide some of the finest set pieces in the novel, ranging from ritual maiming to overpowering a King Cobra in the jungles of the North-east to video nights beyond the platforms of New Delhi railway station. Tejpal is not picnicking in the proverbial Other India; he is not romanticising the essential savagery of the Indian countryside either. And he is too smart a storyteller to succumb to the temptations of biography, even though the narrator is a journalist and the magazine is desperately looking for a backer. *The Story of My Assassins* is an argument with power, a counter-narrative from someone who has been chosen by the state to sustain a lie. Four years ago, Tejpal wrote in his first novel, *The Alchemy of Desire*: "You had to find your words. You had to find your story." The words here make the story of India a lot more interesting.

EXCERPT

Penguins and Killers

There was a moment—when I first saw them—that I experienced a fleeting rush of curiosity and distaste, but it was quickly gone, submerged in a profound indifference. All I wanted to do was to get out of that place as quickly as possible.

The huge high-ceilinged room was packed. There was a continuous eddy of movement as bodies pushed in and out, talking to one another in whispers. The emotional registers all around were high: every face appeared marked by anxiety, fear, aggression, resentment, despondency. The only calm ones seemed to be the black coats dotting the landscape, penguins in their element, skating smoothly through the heartless glacier of organized justice.

Within five minutes of entering the stately iron gates of the Patiala House courts I'd become aware that I was entering a zone of experience that would forever change the way I looked at the wonder that was India. Before the day was out I would know that no middle-class Indian, from any old St Mary's John-Mark school with trilling nuns and caning fathers, who twittered in the queen's English and held forth on freedom and democracy, had any